First DARCYS Awards Honor Disability Stories in Film and TV

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On Saturday, **Easterseals** held the first **Easterseals Disability** Arts & Culture Awardsnicknamed The DARCYsin Santa Monica, California. The ceremony, formerly known as the Media Access Awards, celebrates authentic **disability representation** in movies, television, and media.

Among the **inaugural** winners highlighted in coverage were the HBO Max drama "The Pitt" and the Sundance film "Take Me Home." In the published winners list, "Horsegirls" took Best Feature, Anna Sargent won recognition tied to "Take Me Home," and "The Haunting of Pennhurst" won Best **Documentary**. **Committees** of filmmakers, critics, past honorees, and guild and nonprofit representatives chose nominees and winners; most committee members are people with disabilities.

Comedian and **disability** advocate Tina Frim hosted. The night also honored Geri Jewell with the **inaugural** DARCYS Legacy Award and Vincent Rutley with the Christopher Reeve Emerging Talent Award. Artist and **disability** culture leader Lachi performed. **Easterseals** Southern California and Film Independent co-produced the event at the Historic Barker Hangar.

Nancy Weintraub of **Easterseals** Southern California said the awards continue a legacy that began in 1979 and congratulate storytellers "changing how **disability** is seen." Shawn Davis of Film Independent called the DARCYS a new chapter in recognizing artists who broaden perspectives on screen and behind the scenes.

Guests included Marlee Matlin and other actors and advocates. For kids who love movies, the message is clear: inclusive casting and storytelling are being celebrated as part of excellence in entertainment.

Word Treasure

Easterseals -- An organization that supports people with disabilities and helped create these awards.

representation -- How people and their experiences are shown in movies, TV, and other media.

inaugural -- The first time an event or award of this kind is held.

committees -- Groups of people who review nominees and choose winners.

documentary -- A nonfiction film that tells a true story with real people and events.

disability -- A condition that can affect how a person moves, senses, learns, or takes part in daily life.

Background you need

Awards shows honor people and projects that a community wants to celebrate.

Disability representation means showing disabled characters and creators in honest, respectful ways.

Committees of filmmakers, critics, and advocates often judge nominees.

Events like these aim to push the entertainment industry toward more inclusion on screen and behind the camera.

Break it down

LEAD: Inaugural DARCYS awards honor disability arts and culture
KEY EVENT: Saturday ceremony in Santa Monica co-produced by Easterseals and Film Independent
+- HIGHLIGHTED WINNERS: The Pitt and Take Me Home among honorees; Horsegirls Best Feature
+- SPECIAL HONORS: Legacy and emerging talent awards
PROCESS: Committees with many disabled members choose nominees and winners
STATEMENTS: Leaders emphasize inclusion on screen and behind the scenes
OPEN QUESTION: How the new brand will grow after year one

Why it matters

Awards spotlight stories that include disabled people honestly. Kids who love movies can see that inclusion is part of creative excellence.

Test what you remember

1. What are The DARCYS?

- (A) New awards for disability representation in media
- (B) A type of race car
- (C) A math test
- (D) A weather alert

2. Which organization helps present the awards?

- (A) A hardware brand only
- (B) Easterseals
- (C) A baseball league alone
- (D) Only a grocery store

3. Where was the ceremony held?

- (A) A closed library basement with no guests
- (B) Santa Monica, California
- (C) The Moon
- (D) Underwater only

4. Which Best Feature winner is named in the published list?

- (A) A cookbook
- (B) A blank title with no name
- (C) Only a weather report
- (D) Horsegirls

5. Who hosted the ceremony?

- (A) A silent robot with no name
- (B) A weather balloon
- (C) Tina Frim
- (D) Only a sports referee

6. Who makes up a majority of the judging committees?

- (A) Only robots
- (B) Individuals with disabilities
- (C) Only people who never watch films
- (D) Only sports coaches

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: B 4: D 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Nancy Weintraub: Says the DARCYS continue a legacy since 1979 and congratulate storytellers changing how disability is seen.

2. Shawn Davis: Calls the awards a new chapter celebrating artists who broaden perspectives across film and TV.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):